

GS Relative Clauses

WHAT THIS STRUCTURE MEANS

Relative clauses allow you to embed additional information inside a sentence without breaking the flow of your argument. At ILR 3, relative clauses are not decoration — they are how you qualify, specify, and layer meaning efficiently. A speaker who can say 'the policy that most directly affects low-income households is the one that has received the least scrutiny' has done analytical work inside a single sentence. Relative clauses let you be precise without being slow.

WHAT TO TRY

- Use relative clauses to specify which version of a concept you are arguing about
- Embed qualifications inside the noun phrase rather than adding separate sentences
- Use non-restrictive clauses (which, who) to add context without changing the core claim
- Use restrictive clauses (that) to narrow your focus to a specific subset or condition
- Stack relative clauses carefully to show complex relationships without losing clarity

SENTENCE STARTERS

- "The approach that has shown the most consistent results is..."
- "Populations who lack access to X are disproportionately affected by..."
- "The assumption that underlies this policy is one that has not been fully examined."
- "What tends to be overlooked is the group that stands to lose the most, which is..."
- "The version of this argument that I find most compelling is the one that..."

EXAMPLE IN ACTION

Topic: How should societies address the digital divide?

*"The communities **that are most affected by** the digital divide are often the same ones **that have the least access to** the institutions **that could address it**. Infrastructure investment, **which tends to follow existing economic patterns**, **may not reach** rural or low-income areas without deliberate policy intervention. The argument **that market competition alone will solve the problem** assumes a level of profitability **that does not exist** in underserved markets. A more effective approach **that has shown results in several countries** involves public-private partnerships **that share both the cost and the risk** of expansion."*

Bold phrases mark active relative clause moves — specifying, qualifying, and embedding analytical precision within the argument.